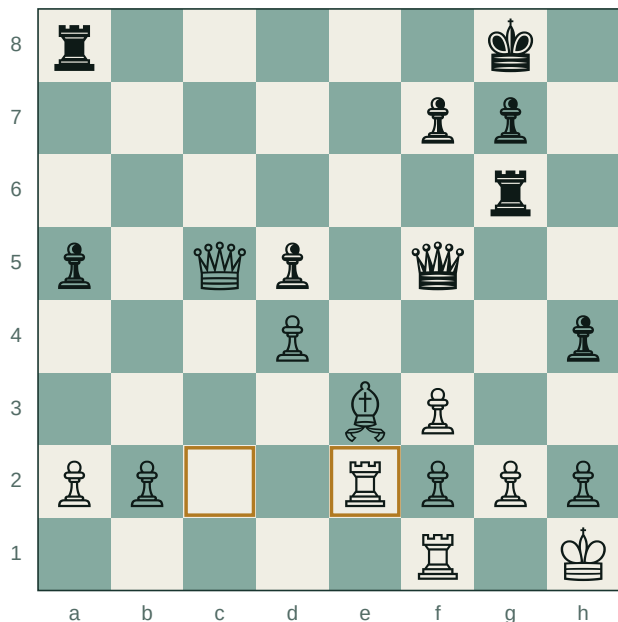


Advanced-pawn tactics: Black, move 21

Advanced-pawn tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 21.Re2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21...h3 22. Qc2 hxg2+

21...h3 The pawn moves from h4 to h3. Recorded reply: **22.Qc2**.

22...hxg2+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From g2 it attacks king on h1 and rook on f1.

At the end, nominal material is White 28 / Black 24 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1:** the balance goes from -5 to -4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A far-advanced pawn may be weak if unsupported. Check whether the opponent can capture it with tempo or blockade it permanently.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A pawn near promotion forces the defender to respect urgent threats. Its strength can create forks, deflections, or mating ideas even when it never actually promotes.

HOW TO LOOK

Count the remaining pushes and identify the blocker. Look for forcing moves that remove or distract that blocker.

The defending king is on h1. Geometrically undefended: rook on e2 and rook on f1. Check for tactical protection.